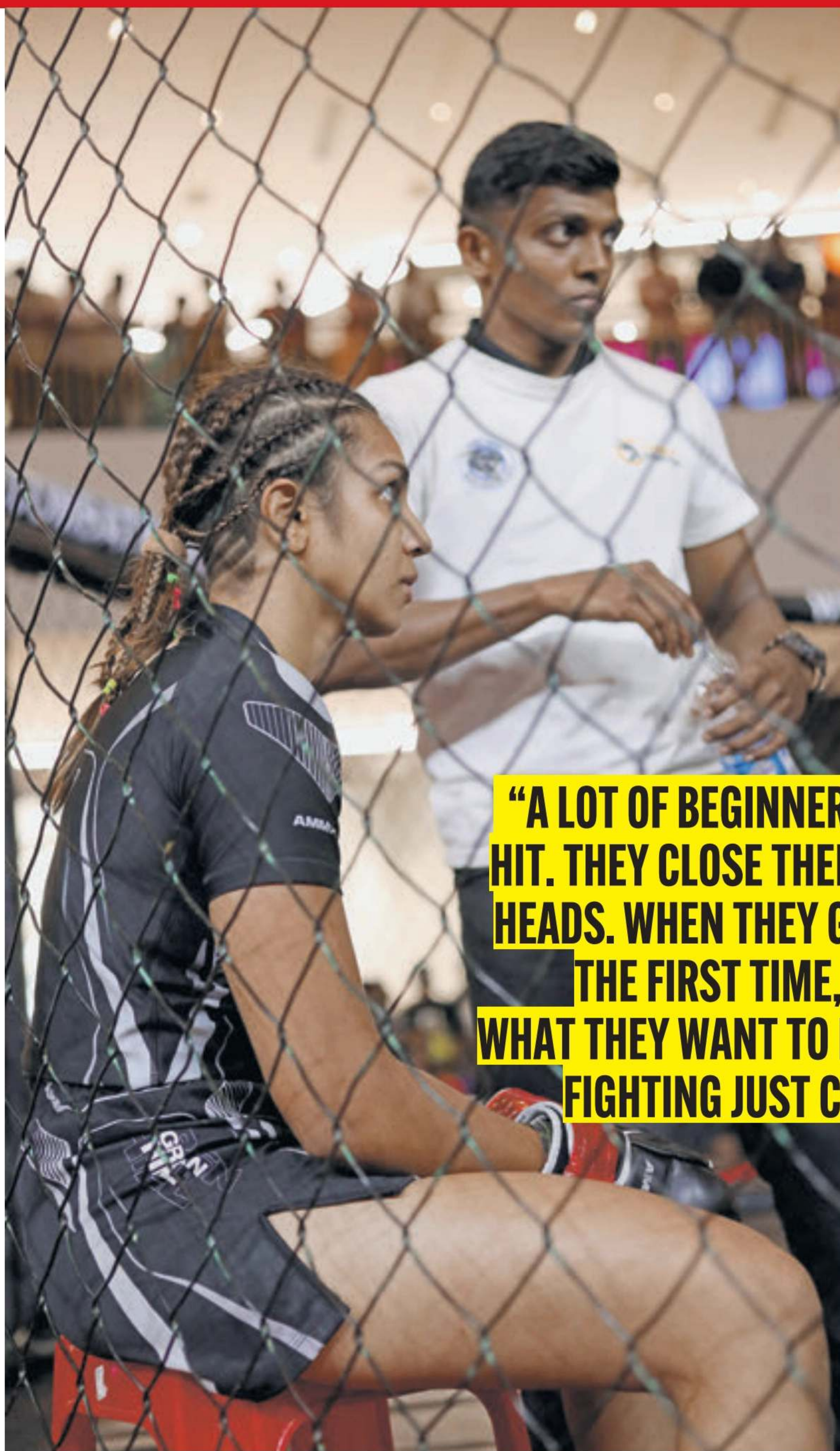




Afshan has to keep herself motivated even when it's not the easiest. Within her family, Afshan says she is a bit of a polarising figure. "Just because I'm a fighter doesn't mean everyone's opinion has changed. My family is still very conservative. A lot of people wonder

why I'm still not married. Both my younger sisters wear the hijab, and most of my cousins still wear the burkha. My relatives tell them not to hang around with me because I'm seen as a bit of a bad influence. My mother loves me, but she will still come up to me and say that I should

Acceptance: Over time, Afshan's parents have come to terms with her choices. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

retire as a fighter and get married. But she doesn't understand that I've only just started," she says.

Afshan doesn't have any regrets. She's already looking to her next target — turning professional. "The amateur system is mostly a way to get some sort of experience. I think I'm a fairly well-rounded fighter. The next level for a fighter is to turn professional. My coach and I are still weighing our options. We have some offers but I'm still to decide whether I want to compete for one more World Championship and win a gold or take the jump into professional fighting," she says.

The professional ranks will be yet another giant step for Afshan to

"A LOT OF BEGINNERS ARE SCARED OF BEING HIT. THEY CLOSE THEIR EYES AND TURN THEIR HEADS. WHEN THEY GET HIT ON THE FACE FOR THE FIRST TIME, THEY DECIDE THIS ISN'T WHAT THEY WANT TO DO WITH THEIR LIFE. BUT FIGHTING JUST CAME NATURALLY TO ME"

climb. She's looking forward to it. "There's this quote I always try to live by. It's that the mountains you carry are the ones you have to climb. There's no point taking pressure because of everything that I had to get through to get to where I am. When I look back, I think to myself, 'Wow, I've broken so many stereotypes, not just for women but for Muslim women in particular. Every once in a while, some woman will come up to me and say she lives through me or that she wants her child to become like me. That gives me a lot of motivation. I've faced some hard obstacles. I can deal with next to anything," she says.